

of their software. So in 1983, Richard Stallman, a regular in the hacker community and a programmer at the MIT Artificial Intelligence Laboratory, launched the GNU (GNU's Not Unix) Project citing the change in the culture of the computer industry as the reason for his frustration and the main motivation towards this initiative. And eventually in 1989, the first version of the GNU General Public License (GPL) was published.

The GPL is the first “copyleft” license for general use. Copyleft (a play on the word copyright), is basically a form of licensing and it is the practice of



GNU's not UNIX

using copyright law to offer the right to distribute copies and modified versions of a work and requiring that the same rights be preserved in modified versions of the work, in contrast to copyright law, which is used by an author to prohibit others from reproducing, adapting, or distributing copies of the author's work. The GPL is still the most widely used free software license.

The term free software was coined in 1983 by Richard Stallman when he started the free software movement ‘to satisfy the need for and to give the benefit of software freedom to computer users’. He then went on and founded the Free Software Foundation in 1985 to further help in advancing his idea of free software. Then, in 1986 the Free Software Foundation published the first formal definition of free software. Written by Richard Stallman, this is still the formal definition and states that software is free if the people who gain access to it have the following four freedoms:

- ▶ The freedom to run the program for any purpose
- ▶ The freedom to study how the program works, and change it to make it do what you wish
- ▶ The freedom to redistribute copies so you can help your neighbour.
- ▶ The freedom to improve the program, and release your improvements (and modified versions in general) to the public, so that the whole community benefits.

So, if a license provides all those freedoms, the software covered by that license is considered to be free software. There are many licenses apart from the GPL that meet the criteria of these rules as well.

And however misleading it might be, because of the above definition free software is not the same as freeware. Freeware is software that is available